The Valentine Fairy

By Ernest Thompson

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: Meet Ingrid: It's Valentine's Day and she's given up on all men and life itself.

ACTRESS: And if my day wasn't bad enough already, I get home only to find this curious man in red slippers, a leotard and a lacy skirt. What a day!

ACTOR: And after some initial pleasantries, I, The Valentine Fairy, take Ingrid on a journey analyzing her past loves.

ACTOR: Yeah, right like my love life is important! Geesh!

TOGETHER: The Valentine Fairy by Ernest Thompson

SCENE: *In a New York apartment, defined mostly by its over-eager effort to conform to too many fashions, sits* RUDYARD, *a curious man of 40 dressed in a blue leotard and red slippers and white gloves and lacy skirt, and a rumpled red hat and several days' growth of beard. He thumbs through a worn notebook, checks a slide projector at his feet, checks his appearance.* INGRID *bursts in, raging in a New York accent. 30, hard, lovely, furious, weepy. She throws a box of chocolates on the table, yanks off her coat and boots.*

**NOTE: During the slide sequence, Ruyard and/or Ingrid will have to verbally identify the picture on the slide in order to the audience to follow the scene.*

INGRID: Men. Men! Who thought them up anyway? The experiment's over, it didn't work! *[She opens a window, climbs up, looking as if she's going to jump.]* Misogynist! Misanthrope! Mis ... representer. Mister Potato Head! *[She turns away, picks up the box.]* Candy. 10 years of Jane Be Like Me Be Like Me, I'm Anorexic Fonda ... *[She throws it down, kicks it.]* ... half my life on the Somalian Rice Diet and he gives me candy! *[She sits by it.]* I should eat it, I should *eat* the candy and weigh a thousand pounds. *[Shouting.]* Is that what you would like, a female manatee for a girlfriend? *[She pokes in the box.]* It's a good way to pick out the peanut ones anyway. *[She tries one.]* I

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suppose that's supposed to taste good. Oh, God, that tastes good. *[She spits it out.]* Ecch, puke, Alien! What am I doing? *[Squeezing her stomach.]* I'm already Roseanne Arnold! I've got Barbara Bush Disease. *[She starts to cry.]*

RUDYARD: *[Singing softly.]* You are so beautiful...to me.

INGRID: *[She screams.]* Acch! Who are you? Don't hurt me!

RUDYARD: I'm the Valentine Fairy.

INGRID: Go away! I'm warning you.... who?

RUDYARD: The Valentine Fairy. *[He smiles.]*

INGRID: Oh? I'm Princess Di. Haven't seen old Big Ears, have you?

RUDYARD: You're Ingrid Paloma, you're 31 years old and you work for Fat Cat Advertising. And you're lonely and you're blue.

INGRID: You don't know that. You don't know anything about me. Get out of here! Go! I have a gun! I'll get it, I swear to God, and I'll shoot your face off.

RUDYARD: Oh, boy, I wish you wouldn't. It's so not me. You could try one of the Veterans' Day fairies, they love guns.

INGRID: *[A new tack.]* Look. You just go and I won't tell anybody you were here, I won't report you or anything.

RUDYARD: Well, that's very pleasant of you, but I have a job to do.

INGRID: What job?

RUDYARD: To bring a little love into your heart. To make you believe once again in the power and the glory and the beauty of Ingrid.

INGRID: *[Scowling at him.]* My mother put you up to this. She's not normal.

RUDYARD: *[He smiles, setting up the projector.]* I thought about being a Mother's Day fairy, but I wasn't cut out for it. I like to be able to win a few rounds now and then.

INGRID: Excuse me. Do you mind? Was I evicted or is this still my apartment?

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What is that?

RUDYARD: This is a slide projector.

INGRID: You're going to show me slides?

RUDYARD: Yes, sorry. All the young guys have gone computer. VCRs, laser discs, all very impressive. But it's not me. Could you get the lights?

INGRID: You're not listening to me. Hello? You know why? Because even though-and I'm not asking questions-you're wearing a tutu, you're still one more major big dumb man.

RUDYARD: Well, aren't you kind? What I really am is in something of a hurry, I don't mean to be rude. This is my night, you know. I don't think you'd sit around arguing with Santa Claus.

INGRID: *[Dubious, facetious, but softening.]* What's wrong with Cupid? I thought Valentine's was like his ... bailiwick.

RUDYARD: Cupid is a naughty little boy who likes to fly around shooting arrows at people. He's not a professional. We can't go tossing our affections to the first taker with a cute butt and a je ne sais quoi. You could at least show me the courtesy of listening to my presentation. *[Calming.]* I'm sorry. This is a very stressful night, Valentine's is not what it used to be. [INGRID *looks at him warily. She turns off the light and sits.]* Thank you. *[He puts up the first slide, a heart with the word LOVE.]* Love. A Journey Into Your Heart.

INGRID: *[She raises her hand, skeptical.]* Um. Is this going to be a long journey? Because I do have places to go.

RUDYARD: Let's talk about the three Rs! Rage, Resentment, self-Recrimination. Is that what you want to do, you want to spend my valuable time and the rest of your life in line at a pity party?

INGRID: Huh? No. I don't believe I do, actually.

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RUDYARD: All right then. Good. *[He puts up a slide-a bird feeding its young.]* Let's go back to the beginning, when we were young, let's focus for a moment on what our dear old mother gave us.

INGRID: Worms.

RUDYARD: *[He laughs.]* Well, that's very funny, Ingrid. *[He makes a note.]* Humor still functioning. Now. *[He changes slides-a middle-aged man.]* Dad. Daddy. Papa. Pops. Pete. Petey.

INGRID: Pervert. Where did you get that? You know my old man? What, did you meet him in Bellevue?

RUDYARD: We had a problem with father, did we?

INGRID: *[Quietly.]* He did not respect me.

RUDYARD: I'm sorry. *[He pauses, affected. Puts up a new slide--a man of 25.]* And what about this person?

INGRID: That's my husband! Where'd you get that? I'm dead, right? I got hit by a cross town bus when I jumped out of the cab. And you're really an angel. And I'm an atheist.

RUDYARD: Was it moving? The cab.

INGRID: The cab was parked at the red light in front of Papaya King, where my most recent boyfriend-I'm surprised you don't have his picture, too, you're not very up to date ... My most recent boyfriend decided to inform me it was time to reevaluate our relationship. I think that's a very romantic spot, don't you, the Papaya King, to have your heart broken?

RUDYARD: *[Making a note.]* And now ... he doesn't love you ... any more.

INGRID: He doesn't love me any less. Ha ha. He told me he has so much love it was only fair to share the surplus with girls who don't have any. I think sometimes that's the only language men know, the mixed message. A kiss goodbye and a box of candy. "I just need a little outside *company*, but

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I'll always love you, fatso."

RUDYARD: You're angry, aren't you? *[He makes a note.]*

INGRID: No. Is that how it seems?

RUDYARD: Well, you're probably better off without him. Forge your own trail through the wilderness, who needs the abuse?

INGRID: Am I going to get a bill at the end of the 50 minutes? Because you are not the first know-it-all in a skirt to point out the obvious. You're not even the first one in a skirt and beard. I'm sorry. If I hurt your feelings. I didn't mean any harm.

RUDYARD: Doesn't matter. I'm used to it. Being a fairy is not something that immediately commands respect. *[He smiles bravely.]* But this is not about me and my poor trod upon feelings. This is about Ingrid. What are we going to do about Ingrid?

INGRID: *[Affected.]* You're very kind, aren't you? That's nice. That's an unusual commodity for a man. Or for anybody for that matter. You're an unusual person. Or whatever you are. Are you really a fairy?

RUDYARD: Yes.

INGRID: What ... what are you doing here?

RUDYARD: Wherever there's a need, that's where we go. If it's an emergency, we stay till the danger passes. We're just like the Marines, except we don't beat up gay people. *[He salutes.]*

INGRID: And what, I'm an emergency, is that the idea?

RUDYARD: Oh, that's not up to me to say. That's your decision. Anything else we want to say about the candyman or shall we put him where he belongs? *[She shakes her head, troubled. He pulls out the slide, drops it in a waste basket. Goes back through, discarding each slide in turn. Puts up the penultimate, a man in denim.]* Good enough. What about this character?

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Were we going through our lumber jack period?

INGRID: Um. That was Austin. He had a charge account at Ralph Lauren. Bought a lot of outdoor things he never used. Why would someone buy a jet ski in Manhattan? He couldn't handle intimacy.

RUDYARD: *[Next slide, a man in black.]* This one? Have Gun Will Travel.

INGRID: Zack. Major Tom Waits fan. We listened to an inordinate amount of Tom Waits. He couldn't handle intimacy either.

RUDYARD: *[Next, a father type.]* Did we put ourselves up for adoption?

INGRID: Mr. Jannislaw, my Human Development teacher at night school. Not a course he was qualified to teach. Also couldn't handle intimacy.

RUDYARD: *[Next, a very young man, cute.]* Ah ha. Ingrid's revenge.

INGRID: He was 19. Delivers groceries for Gristedes. Hadn't heard of intimacy.

RUDYARD: *[Next, a handsome black guy.]* Uh oh. This is a picture we should send to Dad.

INGRID: That was Willy. He was OK. He just hated white girls. *[Next slide, a gentle-faced man.]* He hated all girls, as it turned out. He was standing on the brink of homosexuality and I pushed him over.

RUDYARD: *[Next, a beefy jock.]* Not this one, too? The gay community's going to nominate you for sainthood.

INGRID: No. That was Rick. He loves girls. Loves to beat the *crap* out of them.

RUDYARD: *[Next, a bookworm type.]* This person never beat the *crap* out of anybody. I could take this person on.

INGRID: Alden. Very smart boy. Did the Times crossword puzzle on the typewriter. He broke the news to me that I'm stupid. *[Next slide, male, 40 and glum.]* My boss. No comment. *[Next slide, a young guy.)* Ronnie, couldn't handle intimacy. *[Another slide, another guy.)* Couldn't handle intimacy. *[Another.)* Couldn't handle intimacy. *[Another.)* Couldn't handle me. *[Another.)*

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Couldn't handle my mother. Him I liked okay. *[Another.]* He died. Not of AIDS. He died of jumping in front of the IRT Uptown express, I try not to personalize. *[Another, a teenager.]* That's Chip. Good old Chipper. We loved each other, until I got pregnant. *[Another teenager.]* Tommy. We couldn't figure out how to get pregnant. *[Another teenager.]* Morgan. First base. *[Another, very young.]* Ben. There was no first base. *[A ten year old boy.]* Oh. Christopher. Sweet little Christopher. First kiss. *[Donny Osmond.]* Donny. The only boy who never broke my heart. [RUDYARD *turns on the lights.* INGRID *looks, dazed, upset.]* That's it? That's my whole resume? That makes the guys in the post office look interesting. What is the point of this? I *mess* up every single relationship *I've* been in and I should have my license revoked? Is that going to put you in the Fairy Hall of Fame? You're a genius fairy, big deal.

RUDYARD: It's not part of my job description to draw conclusions, sorry. At least you've got something to work with here. Some of my clients think life is a Judith Krantz novel. I would merely point out, once upon a time you loved every one of those boys and men-and woman-and had faith and a very nice ride at 90 miles an hour, till you smashed your face into the hard brick wall of disappointment and almost bled to death. It's time to get back behind the wheel, Ingrid, and go find your innocence again before it's too late ... You know what's going to happen to you, you're going to turn into *an angry* old broad, it's not an attractive image.

INGRID: Well let's not be cheery, I hate that. So what if I'm *angry*? I like being *angry*?, it's something to feel anyway. I hate men, I hate women, I hate myself, I'm starting to look like Elizabeth Taylor in her John Warner phase. *I've* had a very hard time! OK?

RUDYARD: I'm sorry.

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INGRID: You don't know what you're talking about, you're just a fairy.

RUDYARD: Right. *[He waits patiently.]* I have another slide for you, if you're interested.

INGRID: Oh, we forgot someone? Who is it, Quasimodo? I thought it was character building. *[He puts up a slide of a little girl.]* Who's that? That's me. That's me. You could at least've found a picture with teeth. That's embarrassing. *[But she stares at the picture.]*

RUDYARD: You used to love her. Didn't you?

INGRID: *[For a moment it looks as if she'll give in to it, but then turns.]* Why are you showing me this?

RUDYARD: Because. Because you weren't mad yet. You were filling out all those little wispy Valentines children inexplicably give one another. "I love you, Ingrid." "Your friend forever, Ingrid." Because every time your heart breaks it's harder to put it back together. Because half my clients have died from love, or are dead inside. Because you still have a fighting chance; look at the little girl.

INGRID: Could you turn that off, please? You were on a roll there for a minute, but this is not inspired, I'm telling you. *[He keeps the slide up, waiting.]* Get away, go on! Leave a person in peace to jump out the window, maybe that's what I'm gonna do. No, first I'm gonna eat the chocolates, then I'm gonna jump out the window. Would you please leave now? I don't need help, thank you just the same. And if I did, I wouldn't be seeking it out from some bad joke in red toe shoes. OK? Go away! This is not a Frank Capra movie. This is the Ingrid Paloma Story and it ain't gonna have a happy ending, I can tell you that right now. Go! *[She pushes him.]* There's the door. Or are you gonna fly like Tinkerbell? Where's the magic, incidentally? You're a phony, did you know that? [RUDYARD *looks as her*

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grimly. He nods, packs up his slide projector, the image of the little girl staying on the wall. He seems darker now, stronger than before.]

RUDYARD: You're right. I'm too old for this. Should've been a Thanksgiving fairy when I had the chance. They've got it made. A few family squabbles and all you can eat. And a little clinical depression, sounds good to me. But I'll tell you this, Ingrid, you're a big fat spoiled brat. Sorry, I didn't mean fat. *[Checking his notebook.]* I've got a 78 year old woman in the Bronx, and a priest downtown-they're the worst, want love, can't have love, get love anyway, get in trouble-but at least they still have hope. There are plenty of people out there who could use a good fairy. *[He glances at the audience.]* But you-you be careful. You're only as stupid and worthless as you want to believe. Who cares if all the *men* in the world love you or not, if you don't love yourself, you big baby? Don't you read the Valentines? *[He's ready to go.]* "If you can dream-and not make dreams your master ... " Ah, forget it. That's Kipling, by the way. *[He starts out.]* Usually I go in a poof of smoke, but, you know-budget cuts.

INGRID: *[Picking up the waste basket.]* What about the slides?

RUDYARD: They're your problem, you sort 'em out.

INGRID: What about her? How'd you do that anyway?

RUDYARD: Well, there's got to be a little magic, even in a recession. *[He salutes, gives the audience a knowing look, and walks out.* INGRID *watches him go, anxious.]*

INGRID: Well, wait a minute. What if I decide I'm an emergency? *[No response, he's gone.]* Emergency, emergency! *[She starts to cry, drops the waste basket behind a chair, sits.]* Everybody hates me, nobody loves me, I'm goin' out and eat chocolates. *[She opens the box.]* Big fat juicy ones, long yucky buttercreams ... *[She cries. Traipses to the window like a child. She*

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climbs up. It looks as if she's going to jump. But she tosses a piece of candy, calling.] Candy for the homeless. Valentines for the loveless. Free Valentines. From Ingrid, with love. *[She dumps out the box. Starts to throw it. Steps in, crumpling it. Drags out the waste basket, sits on the floor, drying her eyes. She turns the basket over. Instead of slides, hundreds of Valentines tumble out, covering her lap. She stares in wonder. Picks one up.]* "To Ingrid. When you grow up, I'm gonna marry you. Love, Christopher." Well, I'll let you know, Christopher, if that ever transpires. *[She tucks the card in her blouse, pulls a pillow off the couch and an afghan and curls up on the bed of Valentines. Too tired to get up, she yanks the lamp cord out of the wall. The room is dark except for the slide.* INGRID *gazes up at it.]* Good night, little girl. *[She closes her eyes. Pause.]*

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AWARD HISTORY

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